

Karen Nershi

Middlebury Institute of International Studies
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Academic Appointments

Middlebury Institute of International Studies (2024–present)

Assistant Professor of Cybersecurity, Threat Intelligence Program
Director, Cyber Collaborative

IE University (2023–2024)

Assistant Professor of Political Science, School of Politics, Economics, and Global Affairs

Stanford University (2021–2023)

Postdoctoral Fellow, Stanford Internet Observatory
Postdoctoral Fellow, Center for International Security and Cooperation (CISAC)

Education

University of Pennsylvania (2021)

Ph.D. in Political Science

Topic: Anti-Money Laundering Regulation

Committee: Beth A. Simmons (chair), Edward D. Mansfield, Julia Gray

- **Summer Institute in Computational Social Science Methods**. ETH Zürich (2019)
- **Empirical Implications of Theoretical Models**. Turin, Italy (2018)

M.A. in Political Science (2018)

University of Alabama (2013)

B.A. in International Studies

Summa cum laude, Phi Beta Kappa

Research Interests

Cybersecurity, Ransomware, Cryptocurrency Regulation, Cybercrime, Anti-Money Laundering Enforcement, Causal Inference Methods

Peer-Reviewed Research

Nershi, Karen. Informal Allies: State-Cybercriminal Alignment in the Ransomware Ecosystem
Journal of Cybersecurity. (Forthcoming)

- **Media:** [WIRED](#); [The Washington Post](#); [The Economist](#); [SC Media](#).
- **Podcasts:** [Infosecurity Magazine](#); [Integrity Insights](#).

Nershi, Karen. How Strong Are International Standards in Practice? Evidence from Cryptocurrency Transactions. *Political Science Research and Methods*. [\[Link\]](#) [\[Data\]](#)

Working Papers

Nershi, Karen, Ayse Lokmanoglu, and Samantha Bradshaw. Battlefield Dynamics and Violent Online Narratives: A Study of Wagner Group’s Social Media Messaging During the War in Ukraine.

Nershi, Karen and Selina Hofstetter. Does Rank Choice Voting Increase Electoral Chances for Female and Minority Candidates? Evidence from California Local Elections.

Nershi, Karen. Quantifying International Pressure: Synthetic Estimates of the Economic Impact of Blacklisting.

Selected Works in Progress

Are LLMs Transforming Cybercriminal Operations? A Study of LLMs on Dark Web Marketplaces. (*with Samantha Bradshaw*)

What Motivates Cybercriminals? Interviews with Telegram’s “Hackers.” (*with Ryan Shandler*)

Ransomware Attacks and Electoral Dynamics.

Grants, Awards, and Fellowships

External Grants

“Are LLMs Transforming Cybercriminal Operations? A Study of LLMs on Dark Web Marketplaces.” **Co-PI**, *The AI Security Institute*. 113,000 GPD (2025)

Prizes

Perry World House Foreign Affairs Emerging Scholars Policy Prize, *Perry World House*. (2023)

Internal Grants

Faculty Development Award, *Middlebury Institute of International Studies*. (2024, 2025)

Cyber Policy Center Research Grant, *Stanford University*. 3,000 USD (2022)

GAPSA-Provost Fellowship for Interdisciplinary Innovation, *University of Pennsylvania*. 6,000 USD (2020)

Browne Center for International Politics Research Grant, *University of Pennsylvania*. (2018, 2019, 2020)

Fellowships & Affiliations

Non-Resident Fellow, Center for Security, Innovation, and New Technology, *American University*. (2025–present)

Center for International Security and Cooperation Fellow, *Stanford University*. (2021–2023)

Perry World House Graduate Associate, *University of Pennsylvania*. (2020–2021)

Foreign Language & Area Studies Fellowship (Arabic), *U.S. Department of State*. (2016)
 Benjamin Franklin Fellowship, *University of Pennsylvania*. (2015–2020)
 Young Investigator Scholarship, *Network for the Advancement of Social and Political Studies*.
 (2018)
 Critical Language Scholarship (Arabic), *U.S. Department of State*. (2013)

Public Commentary and Reports

Nershi, K. (2023). “The Slow and Steady Regulation of Cryptocurrency.” *Inkstick Media*. [DOI](#).

Grossman, S., DiResta, R., Ramali, K., Sharma, R., Bradshaw, S., and **Nershi, K.** (2021). “In Bed with Embeds: How a Network Tied to IRA Operations Created Fake ‘Man on the Street’ Content Embedded in News Articles.” Stanford Digital Repository. [DOI](#).

Teaching

Middlebury Institute of International Studies

Cyber Warfare (fall ‘25)
 Cyber Crime (spring ‘26)
 Cyber 9/12 Simulation (spring ‘25, spring ‘26)
 Research on the Dark Web (fall ‘24, fall ‘25)
 Cyber Practicum (spring ‘25)
 Fundamentals of Cybersecurity (fall ‘24)

IE University

International Money and Finance (fall ‘23)
 International Political Economy (spring ‘24)

Conference Presentations

- 2026:** SPSA, ISA, Imagination in Action (Davos)
- 2025:** APSA, Imagination in Action (MIT), CASIS Symposium
- 2024:** APSA, ISA, Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth)
- 2023:** APSA, Empirical Studies of Conflict ESOC (Princeton University), Public Choice Society, Fourth International Empirical Research Conference on Anti-Money Laundering and Financial Crime (Central Bank of the Bahamas), Political Economy of Cyber Conflict (ETH Zurich), War and Peace: Conflict, Behaviour and Diplomacy in Cyberspace (The Hague). Cyber Escalation in Conflict: Bridging Policy, Data, and Theory (UC San Diego).
- 2022:** APSA, Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth), ISA, American Causal Inference Conference, CYBERWARCON, Trust and Safety Research Conference (Stanford University), Politics of Emerging Technologies Mini-Conference, Cryptocurrency and Societal Harm Symposium (Stanford University), Technologies of Deception (Yale Law School), Third International Empirical Research Conference on Anti-Money Laundering and Financial Crime (Central Bank of the Bahamas)
- 2021:** APSA, ISA, SPSA, Second International Empirical Research Conference on Anti-Money Laundering and Financial Crime (Central Bank of the Bahamas)
- 2020:** SPSA, Visions in Methodology (VIM) Job Talk Series, GSIPE Workshop: The Interna-

tional Political Economy of Aid and Development. Polmeth Europe (*cancelled*)

Invited Seminars

- 2024:** University of Chicago, Department of Politics
- 2023:** U.S. Internal Revenue Service, RAAS Innovation Lab 3.0 - Digital Assets.
U.S. Department of Treasury, Data & Analytics Community of Practice.
- 2022:** Cyber Policy Center seminar series (Stanford University).
The Munich Cyber Crime Conference M3C (Maltego).
Oak Ridge National Laboratory “Geek Brief.”
The Stanford Blockchain Seminar (Center for Blockchain Research and the Future of Digital Currency Initiative).
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Academic Service

- Reviewer**, De Gruyter Brill, *Financial Innovation*, *Science Advances*
- Organizer**, Cryptocurrency and Societal Harm Symposium, Stanford University (2022) [\[Program\]](#)
- Organizing Committee Member**, Cyber 9/12 Monterey (2025)
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Advising & Mentoring

- Coach**, Cyber 9/12 Strategy Challenge (2025 & 2026)
- Mentor**, Polmeth Expansions Program, Society of Political Methodology (2023)
- Advisor**, IE University Advisors (2023)
- Mentor**, CISAC Increasing Diversity in International Security Mentoring Program (2023)
- Graduate Associate**, Gregory College House, University of Pennsylvania (2016-2021)
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Skills

- Technology** R, Python, Qualtrics, LaTeX
- Languages** Arabic (intermediate), German (intermediate), French (beginner)
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References

Beth A. Simmons
Professor of Political Science
University of Pennsylvania
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Shelby Grossman
Research Scholar
Stanford Internet Observatory
shelbygrossman@stanford.edu

Julia C. Gray
Associate Professor of Political Science
University of Pennsylvania
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Daniel Nielson
Professor of Government
University of Texas at Austin
dan.nielson@utexas.edu